

Lucian Bessmer, PhD

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Education

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA

Ph.D. Education 2024

Dissertation: *Multiple Paths to Prestige: A Re-examination of the Historical Narratives about Elite Graduate Schools of Education* (revised as *Anchors of Identity*)

Committee: Jal Mehta, Julie Reuben, Alex Csiszar

A.M. History of Science 2019

Ed.M. Higher Education 2014

University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst, MA

B.A. History and Political Science, Phi Beta Kappa 2010

Scholarship

Book Project

Anchors of Identity: The Many Paths to Prestige in the American University. Invited to submit for peer review, Cornell University Press; revising in response to editorial feedback. Approx. 75,000 words.

Comparative institutional history of the Harvard Graduate School of Education, the University of Pennsylvania Graduate School of Education, and Teachers College, Columbia University, showing how each school defended distinct audiences, patrons, and standards of evaluation across four historical inflection points.

Publications

“Beyond Disciplinary Prestige: Applied Judgment and the Construction of Public Policy Expertise.” *History of Education Quarterly* 67, no. 1 (2027), forthcoming.

Under Review

“Anchors of Identity: Reconsidering Narratives of Academic Drift.” *History of Education Quarterly*. Article-length version of the book’s fourth chapter, on the 1970s budget crises at HGSE, PennGSE, and Teachers College.

Works in Progress

Professional Schools and Their Publics: Local Stakeholders in the American University. Second book project. Comparative history of professional schools in the American university, centered on the local stakeholders that shaped them. Cases include public policy, social work, and nursing.

“Local Anchors: How local stakeholders shaped institutional decision-making at UMass Boston, Lesley, and the University of Vermont.” Article on how stakeholders often excluded from

institutional narratives shaped education programs at regional institutions. Archival research complete.

“Making Shared Governance Work: Faculty Senates in Comparative and Historical Perspective.” Comparative study of faculty senates and governance bodies. Interviews complete; historical research in progress.

“Historical Analysis in Strategic Decision-Making: A Framework for Higher Education.” Article on historically informed decision-making and strategy in higher education. In development.

Public Scholarship

“A Call for Historically Informed Decisions.” *Inside Higher Ed*, June 27, 2025. Discussed in Ben Vinson III, “Reflections on Our Times: Higher Education in Focus,” Presidential Address, American Historical Association, *American Historical Review* 131, no. 1 (March 2026).

Book Reviews

Review of *Social Science for What?* by Mark Solovey. *History of the Human Sciences*, online review, (2021).

Review of *The Campus Color Line* by Eddie R. Cole. *Harvard Educational Review* 91, no. 1 (Spring 2021): 136–38.

Review of *American Higher Education Since World War II: A History* by Roger Geiger. *Harvard Educational Review* 90, no. 4 (Winter 2020): 671–73.

Review of *Why Trust Science?* by Naomi Oreskes. *Harvard Educational Review* 90, no. 3 (Fall 2020): 497–500.

Conference Presentations

“Making Public Service Academic: Harvard and the Origins of the Kennedy School of Government.” History of Education Society (HES), Fall 2025.

“We Were Distinguished Misfits: The Clash of Two Knowledge Cultures at the Harvard Kennedy School of Government.” History of Recent Social Science (HISRESS), Spring 2025.

“Multiple Paths to Prestige: A Re-Examination of the Historical Narratives about Elite Graduate Schools of Education.” History of Education Society (HES), Chicago, Fall 2024.

“Field Goals: Three Elite Graduate Schools of Education and their Visions for the Future.” HISRESS, University of Toronto, Summer 2022.

“What is a Profession? The Harvard Kennedy School, 1940–1980.” History of Science Modern Sciences Working Group, Harvard University, Spring 2019.

“Low-Income Students at Highly Selective Institutions.” COFHE Assembly, Yale University, Spring 2016.

Grants and Fellowships

EVP Artificial Intelligence Innovation Program (AIIP) Grant, Harvard University 2026
\$15,000. Principal investigator for a handwritten text recognition tool, developed with the Harvard University Archives.

Division F (History of Education) Seed Funding, American Educational Research Association 2023–2024
\$1,000.

New England Regional Fellowship Consortium Grant 2019–2020
\$5,000. Supported dissertation archival research.

Pforzheimer Grant, Harvard University 2018
\$5,000.

Fulbright Fellow, Sinop University, Turkey 2010–2011

Teaching

Instructor of Record

University of Michigan, Ann Arbor. *History of American Higher Education* Spring 2026
Doctoral seminar.

Harvard University. *Education Schools: Purpose, Expectations, and Impact* Fall 2021
Graduate seminar on the history and purpose of schools of education.

Brown University. *History of American Higher Education* Spring 2020
Undergraduate course.

Course Development

Harvard University. *Data Fluency* Fall 2026
Course for university staff and administrators; member of the development team with the Harvard Teaching and Learning Lab. Pilot overenrolled with a waiting list.

Head Teaching Fellow, Harvard Graduate School of Education

Why Can't Higher Education Change? Spring 2023

Redesigning Colleges and Universities for Equitable Student Success Fall 2022

Transformational Models in Higher Education Spring 2022

The Future of the Liberal Arts College Spring 2021

History of American Higher Education Fall 2017–Fall 2019

Using Data to Support Decisionmaking in Higher Education Spring 2015–Spring 2018

Teaching Fellow, Harvard University

How People Learn Summer 2021

Politics and Education Policy Fall 2020

Creating the Future of American Postsecondary Education Fall 2020

Professional and Research Experience

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2016–Present

Strategic Analytics Fellow 2026–Present

Lead strategic analysis for university decision-making; build shared definitions and standards for institutional data used in planning and governance, including a university-wide data dictionary; and serve on the University Data Advisory Group.

Institutional Governance and Strategy Fellow 2024–2026

Staffed the Senate Planning Body developing Harvard's first faculty senate: researched governance models, interviewed senate leaders and administrators at peer institutions, coordinated the body's work, and wrote its communications to delegates across the university.

Research Lead, History of HGSE 2020

Archival research for the Graduate School of Education's centennial; co-developed a lecture with Howard Gardner.

Development and Strategy Editor, Harvard Educational Review 2018–2020

Guided authors through peer review; trained editors.

Research Lead and Research Assistant 2016–2017

Mapped faculty and resources for the Secondary Field in Education; conducted interviews and prepared historical accounts for a new course in the sociology of higher education.

Consortium on Financing Higher Education (COFHE) at MIT 2014–2017

Assistant Director of Research 2016–2017

Advised senior leaders at 35 colleges and universities on enrollment, financial aid, and student success; directed research projects and supervised analysts.

Research and Data Analyst 2014–2016

Authored reports; conducted statistical analysis.

Research Methods and Technical Skills

Archival and comparative historical research

Interviews and focus groups

Survey design and administration: Qualtrics

AI-assisted research methods: handwritten text recognition, qualitative analysis, developing custom local LLM for the Harvard University Archives

Quantitative analysis and data visualization: SPSS, Stata, R, Python, Tableau, Excel, D3.js

Web development: HTML, CSS, JavaScript